

Phishing Awareness Training

Recognize. Resist. Report.

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What is Phishing?

Definition

Phishing is a **social engineering attack** where cybercriminals impersonate trusted entities to trick victims into revealing sensitive information or installing malware.

Attackers typically aim to steal:

- Login credentials (email, banking, social media)
- Financial information (credit cards, bank accounts)
- Personal data (ID numbers, addresses)
- Corporate secrets and access tokens

Key Statistic

91%
of cyberattacks start with a
phishing email

Cost

Average breach cost:
\$4.9 million (IBM, 2024)

Types of Phishing Attacks

Email Phishing

Mass emails mimicking banks, services, or institutions. Most common form.

Smishing (SMS)

Phishing via SMS text messages. Example: *"Your package is delayed. Click here."*

Spear Phishing

Targeted attack on a specific individual using personalized information. Very convincing.

Vishing (Voice)

Phishing over phone calls. Attackers impersonate banks or tech support.

Whaling

Targets executives and high-profile individuals (CEO, CFO). High financial impact.

Pharming

Redirects users from legitimate websites to fake ones without their knowledge.

How to Recognize a Phishing Email

Red Flags to Watch For:

- ⚠ **Urgency or threats** — *"Your account will be closed in 24h!"*
- ⚠ **Suspicious sender address** — *support@paypa1.com*
- ⚠ **Generic greeting** — *"Dear Customer"* instead of your name
- ⚠ **Unexpected attachments** — *invoice.pdf.exe*
- ⚠ **Suspicious links** — hover before clicking
- ⚠ **Poor grammar & spelling**
- ⚠ **Requests for sensitive data**

Real Example — Fake PayPal

From: security@paypa1-support.com

Subject: *URGENT: Verify your account NOW*

Dear Valued Customer,

We detected suspicious activity. **Click here immediately** to avoid permanent account suspension.

<http://paypa1-secure.verify.tk/login>

- ✗ Fake domain
- ✗ Urgency tactic
- ✗ Generic greeting

How to Recognize a Fake Website

Warning Signs:

- ✗ **No HTTPS** or invalid certificate
- ✗ **Misspelled URL** — *arnazon.com*, *g00gle.com*
- ✗ **Suspicious TLD** — *.tk*, *.xyz*, *.ml*
- ✗ **Subdomains hiding real domain** — *paypal.com.login.malicious.tk*
- ✗ **Poor design** — low quality images, misaligned text
- ✗ **No contact information**
- ✗ **Immediate login/payment prompt**

✓ How to Verify a URL

- 1 Check the **padlock** and **HTTPS**
- 2 Read the domain **right to left**:
login.bank.com → **bank.com** = real
bank.login.tk → **login.tk** = fake
- 3 Use **Whois** to check domain age
- 4 Use **VirusTotal** to scan the URL
- 5 Check **Google Safe Browsing**

Social Engineering Tactics Used by Attackers

Urgency

Create panic to force quick, thoughtless action.
"Act now or lose access!"

Emotion

Exploit fear, curiosity, or greed.
"You won a prize!"
"Your account is hacked!"

Pretexting

Create a fabricated scenario to extract information.
"HR needs your info for payroll."

Authority

Impersonate trusted figures.
"IT Department", "Your Bank", "CEO"

Trust

Use familiar names, logos, and styles to appear legitimate.

Remember

Attackers exploit **human psychology**, not just technology.

Best Practices to Stay Protected



Technical Defenses

- Enable **Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)** on all accounts
- Use a **password manager** — never reuse passwords
- Keep software and OS **up to date**
- Install a reputable **antivirus/EDR**
- Use **email filtering** tools
- Verify links by **hovering** before clicking



Behavioral Defenses

- **Slow down** when emails create urgency
- **Verify** unexpected requests via a second channel
- **Never** provide credentials via email or SMS
- **Report** suspicious emails to IT/security team
- Attend regular **security awareness training**
- Trust your instincts — **when in doubt, don't**

Quiz — Question 1

Question

You receive an email from `security@paypa1.com` asking you to verify your account urgently. What should you do?

- ☐ A Click the link and log in immediately
- ☒ B **Ignore it and report it as phishing**
- ☐ C Reply and ask if it is legitimate
- ☐ D Forward it to a colleague for their opinion



Explanation

The domain `paypa1.com` uses the digit “1” instead of the letter “l”. This is a classic typosquatting technique. Urgency is also a social engineering red flag.

Quiz — Question 2

Question

Which of the following URLs is most likely to be legitimate?

- A `http://www.amazon.com.deals.tk/login`
- B `https://secure-amazon-login.xyz/account`
- C `https://www.amazon.com/account`
- D `https://amazon.login.verify-now.com`



Explanation

Read the domain right to left. Only `https://www.amazon.com/account` has the real domain **amazon.com** before the first slash. All others use fake domains or suspicious TLDs.

Quiz — Question 3

Question

Your “IT department” calls and asks for your password to fix an urgent server issue. What is the correct response?

- ☐ A Provide the password, it is an emergency
- ☐ B Provide only the first half of your password
- ☒ C **Refuse and verify the identity through official channels**
- ☐ D Change the password and then share the new one



Explanation

Legitimate IT staff **never** need your password. This is a classic **vishing** (voice phishing) attack using authority and urgency tactics.

Summary — Key Takeaways

What we covered

- Definition and impact of phishing
- 6 types of phishing attacks
- How to spot phishing emails
- How to verify website legitimacy
- Social engineering psychology
- Technical & behavioral defenses

The 3 Rules

RECOGNIZE

Spot the red flags before clicking

RESIST

Slow down, verify, never rush

REPORT

Alert your team immediately

Your vigilance is the strongest defense against phishing.

Thank You

Phishing Awareness Training

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Useful Resources

VirusTotal: <https://www.virustotal.com>

Google Safe Browsing: <https://safebrowsing.google.com>

PhishTank: <https://www.phishtank.com>

Have I Been Pwned: <https://haveibeenpwned.com>